

Digital Marketing Strategies in Sports Businesses

Halil Erdem Akoğlu, Department of Sport Management, Niğde Ömer Halisdemir University, Niğde, Turkey

Kadir Yıldız, Department of Sport Management, Manisa Celal Bayar University, Manisa, Turkey

Övünç Erdevciler, Department of Sport Management, Ankara University, Ankara, Turkey

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Abstract

The concept of sport provides great opportunities for humanity by growing day by day both for health and as an industry. Especially sports businesses that take advantage of these opportunities intend to exhibit a strong management by keeping up with change in a world where technology is constantly developing in order to compete with their competitors. The continuous innovations brought by the digital environment enable businesses to reach consumers with various strategies. These strategies are generally listed as Social Media Marketing, Pay-Per-Click Advertising, Online Display Advertising, Content Marketing, Search Engine Optimization, Email Marketing, Mobile Marketing. While these strategies are characterized as the most used strategies, technological innovations are constantly adding new applications to this list. The most important of these is artificial intelligence. Artificial intelligence has brought many innovations to the sports environment. As a result, sports businesses are developing digital marketing strategies to reach their fans and customers every day.

Key Points

- Recognize the importance of digital marketing strategies for sports businesses.
- To include applications that will realize digital marketing applications of sports businesses.
- To enable sports businesses to revise their current technological marketing strategies in order to compete with their competitors.

Introduction

Today, sport is not only a physical activity but also a factor that plays a key role in the economic development of countries with the goods and services produced (Bahrami and Kiani, 2023). The sports industry is developing its share in the world economy day by day. The industry's revenue is 487 billion dollars in 2022. By the end of 2023, this revenue is expected to grow by approximately 5.2%, and by 2027 this growth is expected to be over 623 billion dollars. This huge industry includes people and businesses involved in producing, facilitating, or organizing sports activities (Gough, 2023).

Sports businesses are seen as institutions structured to help people organize their social lives and organize different sports activities (İmamoğlu and Mutlu, 2012). Although sports businesses (sports facilities, recreation centers, etc.) are established to provide financial gain in return for the services they provide like all other businesses, it is their primary duty to meet people's sports needs. Especially in countries where sport is characterized as a public service, creating social service and social benefit are prominent elements (Ekenci and İmamoğlu, 2002). In order to survive against their competitors in an increasingly competitive environment, sports organizations keep up with technological developments and design their marketing strategies accordingly. In sport, organizations are always looking for new ways to promote their brand or engage with their followers, and technical developments are often at the heart of these new strategies (Ratten and Thompson, 2021). Technological developments have led to the digitalization of sports as in every sector. Sports marketing in the digital age has evolved with the transition of private sports

channels such as ESPN (launched on September 7, 1979), Eurosport (launched on February 5, 1989) and Sky Sports (launched on April 20, 1991) to mobile technology (Seymour and Blakey, 2020).

To fully understand and implement digital marketing strategies, it is first necessary to know what it is. Digital marketing encompasses all marketing efforts that use an electronic device or the internet. Businesses utilize digital channels such as search engines, social media, email and websites to connect with existing and potential customers. This can also be referred to as 'online marketing', 'internet marketing' or 'web marketing' (Desai and Vidyapeeth, 2019). Digital marketing, which is among the most important activities of businesses, is based on a strategy to be developed by focusing firstly on attracting the attention of the organization, secondly on converting these people into potential customers, and a final stage that will analyze whether the measures and actions taken are consistent with the needs of consumers. In fact, digital marketing has changed the way of attracting customers and retaining them over time (Angosto, 2022).

The term "digital sports marketing" refers to how a sports business or brand communicates and interacts with customers via the internet (Nalbant and Aydin, 2022). Sports marketing in the digital age is built around topics and themes for interaction and conversation. These concepts provide a meaningful dialog for the sports consumer and a platform for the management of sports brands, sports properties and sports organizations. As global penetration rates of smartphones have increased, social media activity has reflected this increase, leading to a fragmented media landscape.

Digital Marketing Strategies

Digital marketers are responsible for ensuring brand awareness and lead generation through all digital channels, both free and paid, available to the company. When digital marketing literature is examined in general, the most effective digital marketing strategies used by sports businesses are listed as Social Media Marketing, Pay-Per-Click Advertising, Online Display Advertising, Content Marketing, Search Engine Optimization, Email Marketing, Mobile Marketing (Brandveda, 2023; Desai and Vidyapeeth, 2019).

Social Media Marketing

Especially in the sports sector, social media has become the most used tool in digital marketing to reach and communicate with more consumers (García-Fernández *et al.*, 2017). This app promotes your brand and content on social media channels to increase brand awareness and generate leads for your business. Channels that can be used in social media marketing include Facebook, X, LinkedIn, Instagram, Snapchat, Pinterest and Google+ etc. (Desai and Vidyapeeth, 2019). Pinterest and LinkedIn are not suitable channels for sports, and successful use of Facebook requires a clearly articulated content strategy. Instagram and Snapchat are the best places to reach young people, Facebook and Instagram reach millennials, and YouTube (Table 1) reaches a male audience (Khoros, 2024).

Pay-Per-Click Advertising

This is a great marketing method to get potential customers. Nowadays, sports organizations can sell tickets, merchandise, and many other things with the help of Google ads. So, this strategy will increase your search result. It will be in the form of an advertisement on a search engine (Brandveda, 2023).

Table 1 Number of Youtube subscribers and Instagram followers of some football teams, sports brands and athletes

Team	Youtube	Instagram
Barcelona	14.3 Million	123 Million
Real Madrid	9.06 Million	146 Million
Liverpool	7.92 Million	43 Million
Manchester United	7.06 Million	63 Million
Los Angeles Lakers	605 thousand	23.2 Million
Chicago Bulls	291 Thousand	9.9 million
Sports Business		
Nike	1.78 Million	304 Million
Adidas	1.06 Million	27.9 Million
Puma	696 Thousand	13 Million
Athlete		
C. Ronaldo	1.04 Million	604 Million
L. Messi	1.85 Million	486 Million
LeBron James	60.5 thousand	158 Million
Novak Djokovic	69.7 thousand	13.7 Million

Source: Edited by the authors.

Online Display Advertising

Display advertising is the process of promoting a product using an online paid advertisement placed on relevant social media accounts and third-party platforms. These ads contain text, images or video and encourage site visitors to go to a landing page and take a specific desired action or purchase a product. Online display advertising is online advertising that includes banner, plain text, media-rich content and video ads (Goldfarb and Tucker, 2015). The primary goal of display ads is to get viewers to click on the ad to learn more about the advertised offer. Since this strategy requires signing up to an ad network, display ads are the easiest way to get started (Barron, 2020).

Content Marketing

Content marketing focuses on answering people's questions and actually helping them through content, rather than annoying them with unwanted promotions. This includes content such as blog posts, landing pages, videos, podcasts, infographics, white papers, eBooks, case studies and more. Content marketing relies heavily on social and streaming platforms such as Twitter, Instagram and YouTube. These apps/sites are especially used to reach the younger generations. This is because these platforms are popular with the younger generations. In addition to these platforms, virtual and augmented reality has made a huge contribution to content marketing. VR allows consumers to virtually see the areas of sports businesses or to be in the same area with popular players of their teams, which creates loyalty towards the business. According to Greenlight Insights, 62% of consumers said they would be more loyal to a brand that sponsored a VR experience. 71% of consumers said they would see a brand as 'forward-thinking' if it used VR (McDermott, 2017).

Search Engine Optimization

Search engine optimization (SEO) is the process of optimizing your website and content to rank higher in search engines and increase the amount of organic traffic to your site. Search Engine Optimization (SEO), which allows sports businesses to target consumers by advertising on search engines, has proven to be an effective audience acquisition strategy. With the right approach, sports websites can achieve higher visibility and drive more traffic to their pages (Mukhwana, 2023). Unlike traditional online advertising, advertisers only pay when users actually click on an ad. When implemented successfully, SEO consistently reaches the consumer and can deliver tremendous ROI. As SEM becomes more mainstream, the level of competition drives bid prices through the roof (Panchal *et al.*, 2021).

Email Marketing

Email marketing is the practice of sending promotional and informational emails to build relationships with your target audience, convert prospects into buyers, and convert one-time buyers into loyal fans of your brand. Electronic marketing (e-marketing) refers to the use of digital media such as the web, e-mail, wireless media, but also includes the electronic management of customer relationship management and the management of digital customer data (Hudak *et al.*, 2017). Sportswear businesses such as Adidas, Nike, Puma, as well as Golden State Warriors, an NBA team, and Chicago Fire Football Club, an American football club, can be given as examples of e-mail marketing.

Mobile Marketing

"Two-way or multi-way communication between a company and its customers using a mobile environment, device or technology and the promotion of an offer" is called mobile marketing (Hofacker *et al.*, 2016). Much of the growth in e-commerce worldwide is driven by consumers using their mobile devices, phones, and tablets to purchase goods and services. According to Statista's Market Insights report, mobile e-commerce sales reached \$2.2 trillion in 2023 and now account for 60% of all e-commerce sales worldwide. Mobile e-commerce's share of all e-commerce is on a steady climb, rising from just 56% in 2018 to an expected 62% in 2027. The growth in mobile e-commerce sales is even steeper as the entire industry continues to expand globally. Statista analysts expect mobile e-commerce sales of \$3.4 trillion in 2027 (Buchholz, 2023).

The above-mentioned digital marketing applications are the most widely used by businesses. In addition to these, new applications such as Youtube marketing and influencer marketing attract the attention of businesses with the development of technology.

Today, when it comes to digital marketing, we see that artificial intelligence tools are frequently mentioned in addition to various marketing tools. Over time, artificial intelligence has become the center of attention due to its level of progress and the increase in its potential applicability (Jarek and Mazurek, 2019). The use of wearable technology, big data analytics, social media and sensor technologies is said to have changed the way sports are played, evaluated and developed in today's world (Ráthonyi *et al.*, 2018), as well as the marketing of sports (Ratten and Thompson, 2021). The application of artificial intelligence in sports is not only limited to sports performance, athlete talent identification and technical analysis of the game, but sports organizations have also come to the point of offering a customized experience in response to the increasing demands of viewers for content and entertainment. One of the most prominent examples of this is the fan experience in IoT-based smart stadiums. Smart Stadiums leverage the IoT business model with top-of-the-line sensors, WiFi capabilities, cameras, and other internet-connected devices to

improve the fan experience at the game and further increase profitability in sports franchises (Melander, 2016). For example, facial recognition sensors promise to eliminate queuing and long lines at concession stands or food courts in smart stadiums (Hutchins and Andrejevic, 2021).

Conclusion

Digital marketing has revolutionized the sports industry in many ways and has become a powerful tool for sports organizations to promote their brands, reach and engage their audiences. The benefits of digital marketing for sports businesses are (1) Increased fan engagement, (2) Enhanced brand awareness, (3) Greater revenue streams, (4) Better data analysis, (5) Improved fan experience. These benefits encourage many individuals or organizations to use digital marketing.

Perhaps the number one example of sports business in the global market is the ownership of teams in major sports leagues around the world. The richest people in the world have started buying clubs as the sports industry has developed. At the top of the list is Indian billionaire Ambani, the managing director of the multinational Reliance Industries group. Through this group, the 65-year-old Ambani owns the Mumbai Indians cricket team, a founding member of the Indian Premier League, which won its fifth title in 2020. In addition, Steve Ballmer owns the LA Clippers, which he bought in 2014. Rob Walton, heir to the Walmart fortune, bought the Denver Broncos for \$4.65 billion in 2022. These examples are multiplying day by day and the interest of billionaires is shifting to the sports industry.

As a result, sports businesses are developing digital marketing strategies to reach their fans and customers every day. Sports have become an integral part of people's lives and they have a high level of emotional attachment to their relationship with sports. With the addition of branding and marketing practices in sports businesses as a result of this commitment, many events that were once only accessible live have gained different forms with digitalization. Considering the impact of digitalization on sports businesses globally, fan behavior, sports broadcasting, sports industry trends and financial benefits for stakeholders are the foundations of this new digital future. The psychological and personalization profile of the sports world and its monetization is the most important driver of global growth for sports businesses in the near future (Seymour and Blakey, 2020).

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